BRIEF

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The Culture Trap

Why Sentiment Measurement Can Locate Strain Without Identifying the Organizational Systems Beneath It

A research brief on the difference between reported experience and the mechanisms through which work is organized.

BY

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Experience is evidence. It is not the whole mechanism.

Sentiment measurement can show where people experience strain. A culture or sentiment score does not, by itself, identify the organizational mechanisms producing the condition.

Reported experience

Engagement, morale, confidence, and other self-reported scores locate where attention may be needed.

Operating structure

Ownership, authority, handoffs, routing, process load, and performance discipline show how the system is arranged.

SYSTEMS MEASUREMENT

Systems Measurement is Monderman's term for examining the organizational mechanisms people work within rather than measuring only how they feel about working inside them.

The distinction is complementary. Sentiment information has value. It can locate reported strain. It was not designed, by itself, to identify the operating mechanisms beneath that strain. Systems Measurement examines that second layer.

Global engagement rose, then fell in 2024 and 2025.

20%

Share of employees worldwide engaged at work in 2025. The lowest global level since 2020.

Gallup, State of the Global Workplace 2026.

$438B

Estimated lost productivity attributed by Gallup to the global engagement decline in 2024.

Gallup, State of the Global Workplace 2025.

Organizations have measured employee sentiment at global scale for more than fifteen years. Global engagement rose substantially over the longer trend before falling in both 2024 and 2025. The measurement tools located the change in reported experience. The score alone did not identify which operating mechanisms sat beneath it.

What controlled trials show

Programs designed to increase engagement have been tested in controlled trials. A 2017 meta-analysis found a small positive average effect on self-reported work engagement. A later meta-analysis of 54 controlled trials found a similarly small effect. These studies evaluated engagement outcomes. They did not establish that increasing the score caused better operating results.

g = 0.29

2017 meta-analysis

Small positive average effect on self-reported work engagement.

d = 0.24

54 controlled trials

A later review found another small positive average effect.

Boundary

Engagement outcome

The studies did not establish that increasing engagement scores caused better operating results.

Stated values and operating practice are different evidence.

A study of corporate values found no correlation between advertised values and profitability. Employee perceptions of management integrity were positively associated with productivity, profitability, and other performance measures.

Advertised values

- Public statements
- Declared principles
- No correlation with profitability in the cited study



Management integrity

- Employee perceptions
- Observed consistency
- Positive association with several performance measures

A separate research program measured management practices directly, including monitoring, targets, and accountability. Those practices were strongly associated with productivity, profitability, and firm survival. In a randomized trial, firms that adopted better management practices raised productivity by 17 percent in the first year. A nine-year follow-up found that a large and significant management-practice gap remained between treatment and control plants.

+17%

First-year productivity increase in the randomized management-practices trial.

This was productivity, not profitability.

~1/4

Estimated share of measured total-factor-productivity gaps accounted for by management practices.

Within and across countries.

The nine-year follow-up also found that approximately half of the adopted practices had been dropped. It did not establish that the first-year productivity effect persisted for nine years.

From reported strain to the system beneath it.

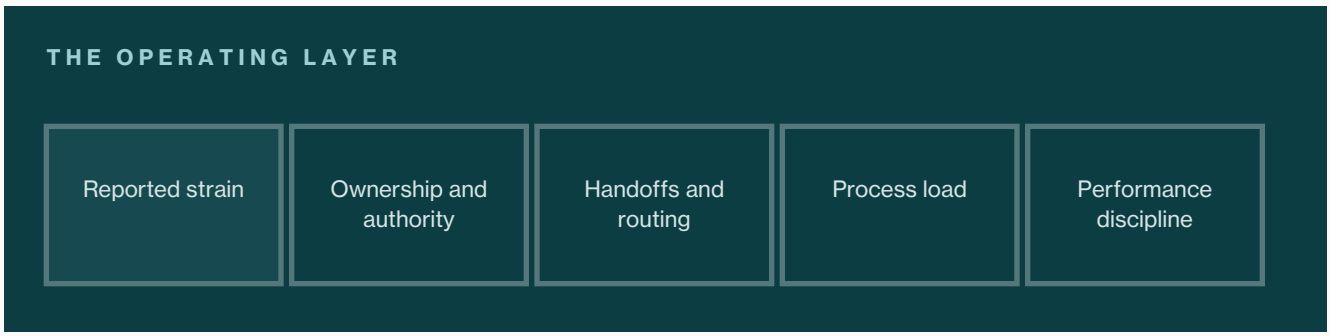
Sentiment measurement

- Asks how people experience work
- Locates low engagement, morale, or confidence
- Tracks changes in self-reported scores

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Systems Measurement

- Examines organizational mechanisms
- Locates strain in ownership, authority, handoffs, routing, and process load
- Establishes a baseline for matched remeasurement



A low sentiment score can show where reported experience warrants attention. It cannot identify whether the condition is linked to unclear ownership, slow approvals, unstable handoffs, excess process load, or another operating mechanism. Those questions require evidence about the system itself.

> Evidence boundary
> The studies cited here did not test Monderman's instruments. They do not establish that Monderman changes performance. They support examining management practices and organizational mechanisms alongside sentiment.

Measure. Locate. Act. Re-measure.

Systems Measurement begins with a baseline. It reports where the organizational system shows strain. The organization acts. A later run measures the same system again.

01	02	03	04
Measure	**Locate**	**Act**	**Re-measure**
Establish the baseline.	Identify where the system shows strain.	Record the response and ownership.	Compare a compatible later run.

What Monderman measures

Research on management practices examines monitoring, targets, accountability, and the routines through which work is managed. Monderman's Diagnostics examine related organizational structures.

Structural Clarity

Examines ownership, authority, and handoffs.

Operational Systems

Examines process load and operating friction.

Decision Velocity

Examines how decisions move.

Institutional Performance

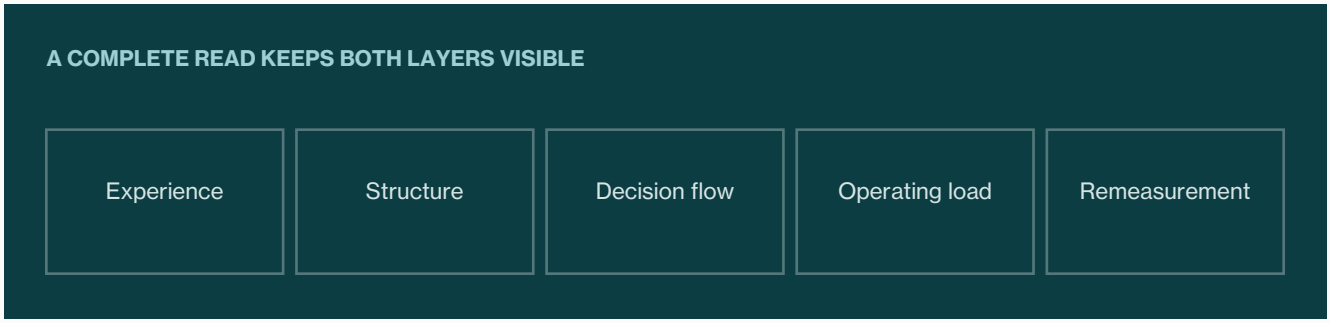
Examines whether structure is converted into sustained performance.

Depth Synthesis summarizes eligible runs of one Diagnostic. Cross-Lens Synthesis compares different Diagnostics and publishes a Composite Score only when the evidence is coherent enough to support one.

Why the distinction matters
The two forms of measurement answer different questions. Used together, they distinguish a reported symptom from the mechanisms that may sit beneath it.

Measure experience. Examine mechanisms.

Culture can affect performance, and operating conditions can shape culture. Use sentiment measurement to locate reported strain, then examine ownership, decisions, handoffs, and process load to understand what may be producing it.



No instrument-validation claim
The cited studies provide evidence about engagement interventions, corporate values, management integrity, and management practices. They did not test or validate Monderman's Diagnostics.

Further reading
Visit www.monderman.com/the-culture-trap.html for the short evidence page, the Platform Brief, and a sample report.

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ABOUT MONDERMAN

Monderman builds organizational diagnostics that collect structured responses about ownership, decisions, administrative burden, and institutional performance. Its versioned scoring system is separate from the AI explanation of completed results.

Monderman.

Organizations deliver at the speed of their administrative reality.

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